
You Watched the Bad Bunny Super Bowl Show. I Watched the “All-American” One. Oh My God.

Published by

Estimated reading time

4 min

Added on

2026-02-09

Address

<https://slate.com/culture/2026/02/super-bowl-2026-half-time-bad-bunny-show.html>

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Just because there’s [one very famous story](#) about an underdog taking on a leporine opponent and winning does not mean it worked out that way for Turning Point USA in its quest to compete with Bad Bunny’s Super Bowl halftime show. In fact, don’t insult the tortoise community by bringing them into this. TPUSA has only itself to blame for the utter lameness of its All-American Halftime Show.

The right-wing nonprofit’s decision to offer counterprogramming to the official halftime show followed a wave of conservative backlash over the selection of the Puerto Rican, Spanish-speaking artist Bad Bunny as this year’s headliner. Though President Donald Trump [has frequently struggled to get big-name artists to perform at events](#) associated with him, he was able to [land Carrie Underwood, Rascal Flatts, and more](#) for his second inauguration, and that was before [Nicki Minaj went MAGA](#). I knew TPUSA’s show wouldn’t be able to compete with the production value or the star power of the real show, but I had no idea it how bad it would be.

Then, about a week ago, the organization announced its slate of performers: Kid Rock would be headlining, joined by Brantley Gilbert, Lee Brice, and Gabby Barrett. Kid Rock, he of [the private jet with a middle finger on its tail](#), embracing Trump is still vaguely disappointing—I’m old enough to remember his glory days, such as they were—but no longer surprising. And if your reaction to the latter of those three names is that they sound made up, well, I was right there with you.

My report after watching? It was as dumb as I expected it to be, but satisfying in one important way: They clearly struggled to fill the room. While it was more crowded than, say, a New York City screening of *Melania* ([I would know](#)), the VMAs this was not. At times, there was enough room between that stage and the extremely subdued audience to safely do a cartwheel. The YouTube stream earned 16 million views, so the audience was not no one, but it’s nevertheless nice to know that when it came down to it, people can criticize mainstream pop culture’s supposedly overly woke values till they’re blue in the face, but they didn’t want to skip their Super Bowl parties for this gallery of has-beens and nobodies. That very much includes our president, who, despite complaining bitterly about the performers, tuned in to the real thing anyway. We know this because he posted a little review on Truth Social: He declared the show “one of the worst, EVER!”

Trump hates to be associated with losers, and he could sense the loser energy from the All-American Halftime Show from Air Force One. I don’t actually believe he watched most of the Bad Bunny performance, by the way—his ADHD is too raging. (His poor attention span is the [excuse he gave](#) for not attending the game in person, though he was probably worried about booing too.) Some of us weren’t as blessed as Trump in this regard. Don’t worry, though: I didn’t have to skip Bad Bunny for Kid Rock and friends. It was pre-negotiated with my editor that I was allowed to watch the real halftime show first.

TPUSA’s event began with an intro by the Department of War’s own Pete Hegseth, which led right into an electric-guitar rendition of “The Star Spangled Banner” expressly designed for the purpose of making Jimi Hendrix roll over in his grave. “This is real America,” some guy whose identity I still don’t know announced early on, a member of a band that seems to require everyone to wear their hair in a faux-hawk and had a song that contained a lyric that went, “My dad taught me how to stand my ground.” *Literally who are any of these people?*, I wrote in my notes. I kept getting bored and picking up my phone to check if anyone had figured out if that was really Liam Conejo Ramos in Bad

Bunny's performance (eventually, [someone did and it wasn't](#)), only to remember that I was supposed to be paying attention. A woman in a blue pantsuit performed—she was my favorite, girl power!—and then a thick-necked man came out to sing about how “it ain't easy being country in this country nowadays.” Sample lyric: “little boys ain't little girls.” This was followed by a song about how he's “hard to love.” I'll bet.

Finally, it was time for the main event, Kid Rock, who graced us with his best-known song, “Bawitdaba” while wearing a fedora and jean shorts. Does it still count as gracing us if he was neither singing or managing to lip-sync convincingly? I feel for him on some level: At 55, it must be a lot harder to summon the energy that song requires, and I'm worried about his joints with all the jumping he does. After singing like, oh, half the song, he left the stage momentarily, at which point a cellist and a violinist came out. He was eventually reintroduced as “Robert Richie,” which is his real name, thus signifying that the night was about to take a soulful shift. He sang a slower song—dammit, I stopped paying attention, again! Sorry!—and before long we rolled into some tribute clips of Kirk. The first, and hopefully last, All-American Halftime Show was over.

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